

Reigning From Death to Life

Open to Luke 16 and keep a finger in Romans 7. We should make it through Romans 7 today so we can move toward what we are after.

Ephesians speaks of the middle wall of partition being torn down and God making of Jew and Gentile one new man. The Jew could not conceive how Gentiles, who had not kept the law, could suddenly come into the same inheritance.

Paul teaches the Jewish community in Rome that the law could not save them. By the law was the knowledge of sin. God lifted up a client nation to serve His altars and receive His law, but the law itself could not make a spiritually dead man righteous.

By Romans 7, Paul shows the state of the Jew married to God through the law while spiritually dead. That marriage produced chaos because the commandments stirred sin into motion.

Romans 7:5 says:

"For when we were in the flesh,
the motions of sins, which were by the law,
did work in our members to bring forth fruit unto death."

Before the law, sin was in the world, but sin was not imputed where there was no law. That does not mean men were spiritually alive. It means spiritual death had no commandment resisting it and exposing it.

When the law said, "Stop sinning," sin moved. The spiritually dead nature rose up against the commandment and dominated the whole being.

The frustration of that is described through the rest of Romans 7:

"The good that I would I do not:
but the evil which I would not, that I do."

The law became the standard by which God declared both Jew and Gentile under sin. Every mouth was stopped.

Romans 7 compares Israel's relationship to the law with marriage. A woman is bound to her husband as long as he lives. If he dies, she is free to marry another.

Long before Paul received this revelation as foundation for the church, Jesus had taught it in Luke 16.

Luke 16:18 says:

"Whosoever putteth away his wife,
and marrieth another,
committeth adultery:
and whosoever marrieth her that is put away from her husband
committeth adultery."

In other teachings on marriage, Jesus includes the clause of fornication. Here He does not, because this saying is not primarily about divorce in the church. It is about covenant.

Israel was married to God through the law. If the law were simply put away and another marriage entered, that would be adultery. But death changes the legal bond.

Luke 16 is a stewardship teaching. Jesus says:

"No servant can serve two masters...
Ye cannot serve God and mammon."

There are two ways to serve mammon. One is the obvious chase after wealth until God's plan is ignored. The other is letting lack of money dictate disobedience. If God tells you to win a nation and you say, "I did not have the funds," then money still ruled your obedience.

The Pharisees were covetous, and this teaching made them angry. They derided Him and heckled Him from the floor.

Jesus answered:

"Ye are they which justify yourselves before men;
but God knoweth your hearts:
for that which is highly esteemed among men
is abomination in the sight of God."

The rich man clothed in purple and fine linen is the picture of what men esteem. God is not against wealth itself. He is against wealth not sanctified to Him, wealth that steps over Lazarus at the gate.

In answer to the Pharisees' derision, Jesus says:

"The law and the prophets were until John:
since that time the kingdom of God is preached,
and every man presseth into it.
And it is easier for heaven and earth to pass,
than one tittle of the law to fail."

They were accusing Him of forsaking Moses and the law. He answers, "The law and prophets were until John. Now the kingdom is being preached, and every one of you will have to press into it. But not one tittle of the law will fail."

Then He says the statement about putting away a wife and marrying another. He is saying, "If I put away the law and marry another, I would be in adultery. Therefore the law must be fulfilled."

Jesus was born of woman, born under the law, and obligated to fulfill it. He was the first Man in four thousand years born spiritually alive, so He could fulfill every jot and tittle.

Then He stepped into His brother's shoes, the Jew under the law, and took the curse. He died spiritually and freed them from the law so they could receive adoption.

Romans 7:1-4 says the law has dominion over a man as long as he lives. A woman is bound to her husband while he lives, but if he dies, she is free from that law.

Paul concludes:

"Wherefore, my brethren,
ye also are become dead to the law by the body of Christ;
that ye should be married to another,
even to him who is raised from the dead,
that we should bring forth fruit unto God."

Jesus became flesh, entered the law, fulfilled it, and died. When He died, the law died with Him, freeing Israel to marry the risen Christ and bring forth fruit unto God, the new nature.

Romans 7:6 says:

"But now we are delivered from the law,
that being dead wherein we were held;
that we should serve in newness of spirit,
and not in the oldness of the letter."

The old man who was held under the law was crucified with Christ. The body of sin was destroyed. The man the law had dominion over is dead.

That is why Paul can say:

"I am crucified with Christ:
nevertheless I live;
yet not I,
but Christ liveth in me."

The old "I" died. The new man lives. We now serve out of the new nature of the born-again spirit, not the oldness of the letter.

Romans 7:7 says:

"What shall we say then?
Is the law sin?
God forbid.
Nay, I had not known sin,
but by the law:
for I had not known lust,
except the law had said,
Thou shalt not covet."

The law is not sin. The Ten Commandments describe the nature of the born-again spirit. But a spiritually dead man cannot know what he is until the law tells him to stop.

Sin took occasion by the commandment and produced all manner of concupiscence. Without the law, sin was dead in the sense that it was unresisted and unexposed.

Paul says:

"I was alive without the law once:
but when the commandment came,
sin revived, and I died."

He was not saying men were spiritually alive before the law. He was alive in conscience because nothing had commanded his nature to stop. The commandment exposed sin and brought it into imputation.

Romans 7:14-17 says:

"For we know that the law is spiritual:
but I am carnal, sold under sin.
For that which I do I allow not:
for what I would, that do I not;
but what I hate, that do I...
Now then it is no more I that do it,
but sin that dwelleth in me."

The Jew received the law with his mind and wanted to keep it. But with the nature he had, it was impossible. He resisted sin and found another law in his members bringing him into captivity.

When people teach Romans 7 as a born-again man excusing his flesh, they separate personal righteousness from sinful acts and say, "That is not really me." That destroys the point of the new birth.

Paul is not excusing a born-again man's sin. He is describing the Jew under law before the new nature.

Romans 7:21-24 says:

"I find then a law,
that, when I would do good,
evil is present with me...
I see another law in my members,
warring against the law of my mind,
and bringing me into captivity to the law of sin
which is in my members.
O wretched man that I am!
who shall deliver me from the body of this death?"

The law of sin and death was the old nature forcing him into captivity. The law of the Spirit of life is the new nature in the born-again spirit that replaces it.

Paul answers:

"I thank God through Jesus Christ our Lord."

Then the great door swings open from Romans 7 to Romans 8.

Romans 8:1-2 says:

"There is therefore now no condemnation to them which are in Christ Jesus,
who walk not after the flesh,
but after the Spirit.
For the law of the Spirit of life in Christ Jesus
hath made me free from the law of sin and death."

This is the pivotal swing from old covenant to sonship, from old nature to new, from death to life.

"Condemnation" is a legal term: condemning sentences under the judicial system of the law. No more condemning sentences can be carried out in the born-again man or woman.

We no longer walk after the flesh, the spiritually dead man under law. We walk after the born-again spirit in newness of life.

The law of the Spirit of life is the law of the new nature in your human spirit. In Christ Jesus, that life first appeared. In Him was life, and that life was the light of men. As the Father had life in Himself, He gave to the Son to have life in Himself, and the Son gave you to have life in yourself.

That law of life has set you free from the law of sin and death.

Sin has lost dominion over you. So have sin's friends: sickness, disease, poverty, depression, and every root of the fall. You have entered the first stage of adoption as a son of God in your spirit, while waiting for the glorified body.

Meanwhile, you have the right to enjoy the inheritance of a son of God.

You are free at last.